Introduction

This course has a 30%-weighted coursework component which will require you to act as a market research agency and produce a market research proposal responding to a client's brief, as if being delivered to the client. This individual project work is treated as an open-book examination.

The Research Brief

The research brief accompanies this document and contains the following.

- A short introduction and background of the company or organisation commissioning the research.
- Business objectives: These will be particular problems or challenges they are facing, or they could be more strategic aims and objectives. Examples of these include:
    - develop / launch a new product or service
    - grow market share
    - raise awareness of a product, service, or a particular message
    - increase customer satisfaction.
- Research aims: These will be specific goals which a market research project would help answer. They could be specific questions which the organisation wishes to answer, or they could be information or insights about a particular population. They will be linked to the business objectives. Examples of these include:
    - understand the attitudes and behaviours of consumers / people
    - learn what factors lead to higher customer satisfaction
    - find out what gaps there are in a market
    - understand the image or associations with a brand or product
    - estimate the demand for a new product or service.
- Some information about what, if any, data the business or organisation can supply, for example a customer database, a sampling frame or operational data.
- An indication of the available budget and required timescale for the research.

The Research Proposal

You will not be expected to conduct any primary research. The report should cover the following areas.

(a) Provide a full summary of the research brief, including the aims of the research.

(b) Demonstrate an understanding of the market or business context as well as any other publicly available research done in this area.

(c) Detail how the fieldwork would be conducted, i.e. face-to-face, telephone, online, focus groups, mixed-mode etc.

(d) Explain the proposed sampling method as well as other sampling methods considered, including details on any sampling frame to be used.

(e) Detail the information that would be gathered and collected by the research.

(f) Explain how you would use any customer or operational data supplied to you by the client.

(g) Describe what multivariate analysis techniques you propose and how these would help the client's research aims. (You are not required to actually *conduct* any analysis.)

(h) Detail the proposed sample size necessary to construct confidence intervals around the survey estimates.

(i) An appropriate questionnaire which would capture suitable data to perform the proposed multivariate analysis. (You are not required to actually run the questionnaire in practice.)

(j) Proposed further research, i.e. include ideas for how some business or organisational objectives might be helped by further and different research.

Marks will be awarded on the basis of the following:

- Demonstration of a full understanding of the client's issue / business problem and the market context.
- A clear explanation of the specific aims of the research.
- Thorough justification of the data collection methods, fieldwork approaches and sampling methods chosen, and also why others were rejected.
- Creativity and imagination in your approach to the research.
- Clear and concise expression of the ideas and your knowledge.
- Demonstration of a clear understanding of the statistical concepts related to sampling and sample size determination.

- Explanation of your chosen statistical analysis techniques and clear examples of how the client will benefit.
- A well-thought out questionnaire design which reflects the aims of the research and intended statistical analysis.
- Creative and imaginative suggestions for further research.
- The quality and professionalism of the research proposal.

The length of the main report should not exceed 3,000 words. You should also include an executive summary at the beginning of no more than one side of A4. Please also include a table of contents. The executive summary and table of contents are not included in the 3,000-word limit. The questionnaire does not count towards the word limit either. The word limit does not apply to text not in the main body such as footnotes and labels.

Please note there is no allowance in the word limit. If you exceed the stated word limit you will be penalised. Please also state the word count. You should use the 1.5 lines setting, exactly as per this text.

If you wish, you may also include a Technical Appendix at the end of the document (excluded from the word count) but the examiners will **not** consider anything included here for marking.

All submissions will be checked using the anti-plagiarism software TurnItIn. Any duplicated text which is not adequately cited will be deemed to constitute plagiarism and proportional penalties will be applied during marking.

You should also provide references wherever possible as this is ultimately a piece of academic work. If finding references for secondary research proves problematic, then please state this and it will be taken into account.

Good luck!